

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

DOW JONES | News Corp

WEDNESDAY, DECEMBER 24, 2025 ~ VOL. CCLXXXVI NO. 149

WSJ.com

★★★★ \$5.00

DJIA 48442.41 ▲ 79.73 0.16% NASDAQ 23561.84 ▲ 0.6% STOXX 600 588.73 ▲ 0.34% 10-YR.TREAS. ▲ 1/32, yield 4.168% OIL \$58.38 ▲ \$0.37 GOLD \$4,482.80 ▲ \$38.20 EURO \$1.1796 YEN 156.23

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Robust spending by U.S. consumers** drove greater-than-expected economic expansion in the third quarter, and the strongest growth rate in two years. **A1**
- ◆ **Major U.S. stock indexes** advanced, with the S&P 500 rising 0.5% to a record while the Nasdaq and Dow gained 0.6% and 0.2%, respectively. **B10**
- ◆ **The estate of Robert Brockman** agreed to pay \$750 million in back taxes and penalties, settling a civil suit that stemmed from what the government had called the biggest U.S. tax-fraud case ever filed involving an individual. **A2**
- ◆ **BP is nearing** a sale of a 65% stake in its Castrol lubricants business to U.S. investment firm Stonepeak for roughly \$6 billion. **B1**
- ◆ **A Baltimore city jury** ordered J&J to pay over \$1.5 billion in a lawsuit that alleged the company's talc-based personal products gave a Maryland woman cancer. **B1**
- ◆ **General Motors** and auto regulators are probing the crash of a 2010 Sierra pickup that injured a passenger after its air bag ruptured. **B3**
- ◆ **Chinese automaker BYD** enjoyed a more than threefold jump in European sales last month, continuing to outpace domestic and foreign rivals. **B3**
- ◆ **Mercedes-Benz settled** with state attorneys general across the U.S. who said an investigation found it used emissions-cheating software. **B3**

World-Wide

- ◆ **The U.S. moved** a large number of special-operations aircraft, troops and equipment into the Caribbean area, giving the administration additional options for possible military action in the region. **A1**
- ◆ **The U.S.'s pursuit** of oil tankers around Venezuela is part of a new legal strategy under the Trump administration to seize ships that transport black-market oil around the world. **A8**
- ◆ **The Supreme Court** blocked Trump from sending the National Guard into the Chicago area, dealing a rare loss to the president on an issue of executive power. **A3**
- ◆ **Three men who escaped** from an Atlanta-area jail were recaptured, ending a tense but brief manhunt for a convicted murderer and a murder suspect. **A3**
- ◆ **Senior military leaders** of Libya's government were killed when their jet crashed soon after taking off from an airport in Ankara, Turkey's capital. **A7**
- ◆ **The Education Department** said that it would resume garnishing the wages of student-loan borrowers who are in default starting early next year. **A3**
- ◆ **Israel won't leave Gaza** and will eventually build Jewish settlements there, the country's defense minister said, intentions that are at odds with Trump's plan for the enclave. **A7**

NOTICE TO READERS

WSJ.com and WSJ mobile apps will publish on Christmas Day. The Wall Street Journal print edition won't be published on Thursday.

CONTENTS	
Opinion.....	A13-15
Arts in Review.....	A12
Business & Finance B2-3	Personal Journal A10-11
Crossword.....	Property Report... B6
Marked on Street... B10	Sports.....
Markets Digest... B8	Technology & Media B4
	U.S. News..... A2-4
	World News..... A6-8



© 2025 Dow Jones & Company, Inc. All Rights Reserved

Consumers Fuel Surge in Growth

Delayed report shows third-quarter GDP increased at highest clip in two years

By CHAO DENG AND HARRIET TORRY

Robust spending by U.S. consumers drove greater-than-expected economic expansion in the third quarter, and the strongest growth rate in two years.

Gross domestic product, the value of all goods and services produced across the economy, rose at a seasonally and infla-

tion-adjusted 4.3% annual rate from July through September, the Commerce Department said Tuesday.

The report was delayed nearly two months by the government shutdown, and looks back at the period before the shutdown was in effect. It does, however, offer a snapshot of an economy that has managed to keep humming along for much of the year.

Growth picked up from 3.8% in the previous quarter, and easily beat the 3.2% forecast among economists polled by The Wall Street Journal.

It was the strongest expansion since the third quarter of

2023. Rising consumer spending was partly driven by healthcare, including outpatient services, and at hospitals and nursing homes. International travel, legal services and spending on products like personal computers and software also contributed.

Artificial intelligence-related spending helped, too, though the pace of growth appeared to cool from the second quarter. Overall business investment growth slowed to 2.8% in the third quarter from 7.3% in the prior three months.

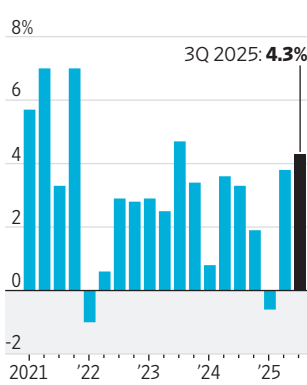
The report offered fresh

evidence that consumers are continuing to lift the U.S. economy, even as inflation remains higher than the Federal Reserve's 2% target, hiring has been sluggish and consumer-confidence readings reflect a dour overall mood.

The Commerce Department will revise the third-quarter numbers and is expected to release its assessment of economic growth for the rest of 2025 early next year.

"We don't know if everything is as good as the third-quarter number suggests, but it is sending the message that

U.S. GDP, change from previous quarter



Note: Adjusted for seasonality and inflation at annual rates
Source: Commerce Department

In the Air There's a Feeling of Christmas



UNDER THE TREE: As dusk settled, skaters took to the Rockefeller Center rink in New York City two days before Christmas.

Inside the Fast Track To Trump Pardons

President Trump had just awarded a posthumous Presidential Medal of Freedom for Charlie Kirk in October when his son ushered friends toward the Oval Office.

By Rebecca Ballhaus, Josh Dawsey and C. Ryan Barber

As a string ensemble played in the background, Donald Trump Jr. walked up with lobbyist Ches McDowell to chat with the president. Trump Jr. at one point pulled McDowell forward to shake Trump's hand, according to a livestream broadcast. After they went inside, McDowell took the president aside to discuss a pressing issue, according to people familiar with the matter: One of his clients was seeking a pardon. The client was Changpeng Zhao, founder of the world's largest crypto exchange, Binance. That afternoon, the president agreed to sign Zhao's pardon, the people said. Zhao was one of the beneficiaries of a new, informal path to presidential pardons that has become a feature of Trump's second term, which allows some clemency applicants with deep pockets or politically connected lobbyists to circumvent the traditional pardon process.

McDowell told The Wall Street Journal that Trump Jr. didn't help him pursue the pardon and had left the room when he brought up Zhao. Trump Jr. had brought him because they were leaving later that afternoon for a hunting trip in Utah, McDowell said. A

Please turn to page A4

Russian Billionaire Fights The Global Fertility Crisis

Telegram founder Pavel Durov has more than 100 children and counting, and has promised each a share of his fortune

Attractive women started showing up in summer 2024 at a fertility clinic in southern Moscow in response to an unusual marketing campaign: free sperm.

By Sam Schechner, Daria Matviichuk and Thomas Grove

The sperm belonged to Pavel Durov, billionaire founder of the messaging app Telegram.

At conferences, on social media and on news sites, the clinic described Durov as having "high genetic compatibility" and

noted he would pay for in vitro fertilization for women under 37 who wanted to use his "in-demand" sperm. A banner on the website of the clinic, called AltraVita, still advertises his "biomaterial" next to a photo of the CEO and a Telegram logo.

"The patients who came, they all looked great, were well-educated and very healthy," said a former doctor at the clinic, who examined several volunteers, adding that participants had to be unmarried to avoid legal complications. "They wanted to have a child from, well, a certain kind of man. They saw that

Please turn to page A9

Companies Tackle Plight Of Introverts

Bosses set aside space to recharge; 'Valuably Quiet'

By RAY A. SMITH

"Passion doesn't have to look like 'rah, rah!'"

Bristol-Myers Squibb employees were giving managers pointers on how to tell whether their introverted staffers are excited about their work.

After all, it can be hard to tell.

"For extroverts, that shows up as visible energy and vocal enthusiasm," Chief People Officer Amanda Poole recalls colleagues who represent the company's "Valuably Quiet" program telling supervisors at one workshop. "For introverts,

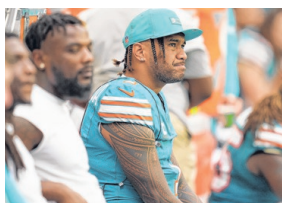
Please turn to page A9

INSIDE



U.S. NEWS

A doctored passport and other documents are released in new batch of Epstein files. **A4**



SPORTS

Miami quarterback Tua Tagovailoa is the NFL's \$212 million benchwarmer. **A16**

Soaring Car Payments Spur 100-Month Loans

By RYAN FELTON

The price of new cars and trucks in the U.S. has increased 33% since 2020, and consumers are piling on interest as they stretch out loan terms to eight, nine and nearly 10 years.

David Kelleher, who runs a Dodge and Jeep dealership in Glen Mills, Pa., 27 miles west of Philadelphia, said many American families can't comfortably take on a new-car payment these days.

"We don't have \$300 monthly payments any longer in new vehicles," he said. "It's a thing of the past."

The average price of a new car broke the \$50,000 barrier this fall, according to Kelley Blue Book. That is up from less than \$38,000 in early 2020 before the pandemic hit. As sticker prices marched

higher, so did monthly payments. For a few years, car shoppers were undeterred. Many needed new vehicles after putting off buying during e Covid when supply chains were upended and dealer lots were empty. Others, feeling flush, opted for luxury vehicles at much higher price points.

Fast forward to November of this year and the average monthly payment for a new car was estimated to be \$760, according to J.D. Power, an industry-research firm. The hefty cumulative inflation is starting to weigh on consumers, and now some Americans are falling behind on their car payments.

The struggle to keep monthly payments in check is so tough that the typical 48- to 60-month car-loan term has

Please turn to page A2

U.S. Adds Aircraft, Troops to Caribbean Operations

By SHELLEY HOLLIDAY AND LARA SELIGMAN

The U.S. moved a large number of special-operations aircraft, troops and equipment into the Caribbean area this week, giving Washington additional options for possible military action in Venezuela, according to U.S. officials and open source flight-tracking data.

President Trump has ramped up pressure on Venezuelan strongman Nicolás Maduro in recent days, ordering a blockade of oil tankers going in and out of the country. Trump has declared that the airspace around Venezuela should be considered closed and has refused to rule out airstrikes on the country.

"We have a massive armada formed, the biggest we've ever had, and by far the biggest we've ever had in South America," he said Monday. Referring to the possibility of land strikes in Venezuela, he said: "Soon we will be starting the same program on land."

The White House and the Department of Defense didn't return requests for comment.

At least 10 CV-22 Osprey tilt-rotor aircraft, which are used by special-operations forces, flew into the region Monday night from Cannon Air Force Base in New Mexico, according to an official. C-17 cargo aircraft from Fort Stewart and Fort Campbell Army bases arrived Monday in Puerto Rico, according to flight-tracking data. A different U.S. official confirmed that military personnel and equipment were transported on planes.

It isn't clear what types of

Please turn to page A8

◆ **U.S. aims to curb global oil black market**..... **A8**